

Agents need an *operating* model.

A point of view for chief operating officers on turning agentic AI into measurable returns in GCC bank operations.

THE ARGUMENT

The model is not the *bottleneck*.

Demonstrations are cheap. Every major bank in the region has seen an agent open an account, spread a set of financials or draft a regulatory narrative. The demonstration takes weeks. A controlled, measured production process takes an operating model most banks have not yet designed.

Value follows the process. Agents earn their keep where work is high-volume, rule-heavy and already measured: KYC refresh, credit administration, reconciliations. Where the process is undocumented, the agent inherits every exception and the return disappears into rework.

The regulator will ask. SAMA, the CBUAE and the QCB expect model risk management, audit trails and a named accountable owner. A bank that cannot show who approved an agent's output, and on what evidence, does not have a production system. It has a pilot.

The technology is ready sooner than the operation is.

“An agent without an owner is a *pilot that never ends*.”



THE READINESS TEST

Where agents are *ready* to earn.

USE CASE	VOLUME AND RULES	MEASURED BASELINE	BUSINESS OWNER	REGULATORY COMFORT
KYC refresh and onboarding	●	●	◐	●
Credit administration and covenant monitoring	●	◐	●	●
Reconciliations and break investigation	●	●	●	◐
Regulatory return drafting	◐	◐	●	◐
Customer-facing servicing	●	◐	◐	○
Complex credit decisions	○	◐	●	○

● Strong ◐ Partial ○ Weak · Indicative assessment from Aspiro engagement experience in GCC banks. Every institution will differ; the test is what matters.

Four parts of an agent *operating* model.

01

Process before agent

Redesign the value stream first, so the agent does work that has to be done rather than work that should never have existed.

02

A baseline and a business owner

Cycle time, cost and error rate measured before go-live, and owned by operations rather than technology.

03

Human-in-the-loop controls

Clear decision rights: what the agent prepares, what a person approves and how exceptions are escalated.

04

Governance the regulator accepts

A model inventory, an audit trail and explainability built in, with model risk management extended to agents.





CASE STUDY

Measure it, then *automate* it.

This programme used automation rather than agents. The discipline is the same: a measured baseline, a redesigned process and controls built in from the first day.

70%

REDUCTION IN PROCESSING TIME

Automated ESG reporting and compliance

Large UAE bank

THE CHALLENGE

ESG data was collected by hand across dozens of business units into spreadsheets, consuming thousands of hours a year and producing numbers nobody could fully defend as IFRS S1/S2 reporting approached.

WHAT WE DID

Designed the ESG data model and control framework, automated collection and calculation using Alteryx, and delivered real-time dashboards mapped to IFRS S1/S2, UAE Decree-Law No. 11 and global standards.

THE OUTCOME

Seventy percent reduction in processing time, more than 1,200 hours saved annually, and audit-grade sustainability reporting.

70%

Reduction in processing time

1,200+

Hours saved every year

Audit-grade

Reporting under IFRS S1/S2



WHAT TO DO ON MONDAY

Four moves before the next *pilot*.

01

Pick two processes

The two with the clearest baseline and a named owner in the business. Not the most impressive demonstration.

02

Build the digital twin

Map the process and remove the waste before an agent touches it.

03

Write the decision rights

What the agent prepares, what a person approves and who owns the exceptions.

04

Brief the regulator early

Share the control design before go-live, not after the first question.

Leading with clarity. Delivering the *difference*.

Start a conversation

ABOUT ASPIRO

Aspiro is an independent, investor-free management consultancy for GCC financial institutions, founded in Dubai in 2015 with offices in Riyadh and London. Its partners carry 100+ years of senior leadership experience, backed by a network of 8,000+ specialists.

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